Hegseth impeachment to pass House then stall

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【メール原文】

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Status quo in Iran more likely than escalation
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Nvidia scandal increases odds of stronger export controls
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Lack of an alternative makes Schumer likely leader

Hegseth's impeachment will likely pass the House, then stall. Rep. Thomas Massie (R-KY) has filed articles of impeachment against Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth which, on the back of a strong Democrat performance at the midterms, are likely to receive a vote and pass the chamber.

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While Hegseth is likely to be impeached, he is unlikely to be removed from office under impeachment proceedings. Once the articles are passed to the Senate, and the impeachment managers appointed, it will require a two-thirds majority vote to convict and remove Hegseth – a bar which is likely out of reach, even with strong Democrat momentum and increasing GOP infighting.
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Speaker of the House Mike Johnson (R-LA) also has the ability to hold the articles before transmitting them to the Senate. Taking a page out of former Speaker Nancy Pelosi (D-CA)'s playbook, Johnson can hold the articles until this session of Congress ends in January, delaying the issue of removal for at least a few weeks.
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Floor time, in the House and Senate, is the chief political concern of both Speaker Johnson and Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-SD). An impeachment trial in the Senate would take up much-needed time to address government funding, defense authorization, energy permitting reform, and other key priorities left to address before Republican majorities evaporate. Speaker Johnson, for his part, is not considering a run for Republican leader in the new Congress, which gives him political insulation to wait

out the clock on impeachment.

Status quo in Iran more likely than escalation. Based on evidence of increasing political constraints on President Donald Trump following last week's midterm losses, namely mounting opposition from inside the administration and GOP, we no longer see escalation with Iran as the most likely scenario (30% odds, down from 60%). A continued standoff is likely through the rest of 2026 (60% odds, up from 30%), while we continue to see a limited deal as unlikely (10% odds, unchanged).

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Trump remains open to breaking the status quo with Iran through force. However, the appointment of Stephen Miller—who has historically leaned towards restraint—as White House Chief of Staff, decision not to strike late last week at the moment of greatest opportunity, and Trump’s own comments downplaying escalation over the weekend indicate that he is less inclined to escalate than he was last week.

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The benefits of escalation would not outweigh likely downsides. New strikes would trigger aggressive Iranian retaliation, while the odds of forcing additional concessions from Tehran through infrastructure strikes are low. There is little appetite on the US side for a more open-ended engagement given concerns over diminished air defense stockpiles.

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The US is managing to move more oil out of the Middle East, but Iran’s attacks on shipping remain an obstacle to returning the strait to its prewar status quo. Iran is continuing to diminish global shipping capacity by hitting one or two ships every day; this will continue to force down flows and put pressure on the US to resolve the conflict as more time passes.

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For more, please see The political window for escalation has closed , 9 November 2026.

Nvidia scandal increases odds of stronger export controls. Nvidia has been the most effective opponent of new export controls, and the Megaspeed scandal undermines CEO Jensen Huang's argument that selling to China keeps Chinese developers dependent on US technology.

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Trump will try to shield Nvidia given its importance to the AI buildout and US-China stability; he reportedly took no action after being briefed in October 2025 that the Megaspeed executive was a suspected Chinese spy.

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The scandal makes it more likely stronger export control bills are added to the NDAA as amendments. The Chip Security Act, AI Overwatch Act, and MATCH act were previously seen as likely to be dropped under pressure from the White House and industry. Doing so now would force Republicans to defend Nvidia days after their own committee summoned Huang.

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However, new chip laws will only matter as much as Trump and the Commerce Department are willing to enforce them. Proposed legislation still leaves the executive room to delay and provide for limited national security waivers.

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For more, please see Nvidia scandal increases odds of stronger export controls , 9 November 2026.

Lack of an alternative makes Schumer likely leader. Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer (D-NY) is facing strident criticism from both sides of the Democratic Party; a number of incoming senators-elect, including progressive Abdul El-Sayed (D-MI) and moderate Adam Hamilton (D-KS) say they won't back him.

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Schumer's position as the probable majority leader is still very likely safe, even if he won't get the unanimous support he had had in his previous elections as Democrats' Senate leader.

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Three factors support this view:

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Schumer is riding high. Schumer is perhaps the biggest winner from Democrats' Senate majority. He can rightly claim that his candidate selections in key races made the difference. This redounds to his benefit in intra-caucus relations.

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There is no obvious alternative. Progressives have suggested Senator Chris Van Hollen (D-MD) as an alternative, but it's hard to see how Van Hollen would have the support of moderates like Hamilton, who criticize even Schumer as being perceived as too far to the left.

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Schumer doesn't need to clear a high bar. The Senate majority leader is a party position, requiring only a majority of the majority—not, like in the House, a majority of the entire chamber. Schumer can easily afford to lose the votes of a few progressives and moderates.

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Once elected as the incoming majority leader Schumer will likely continue to face criticism, especially from progressives, even though it won't threaten his position; that Democrats will have a five-seat cushion will give him the ability to isolate the small number of critical progressives when necessary.

Quote of the Day

"When you cut Medicaid but you fund data centers, when you cut rural hospital funding, then you fund Planned Parenthood, when you let the cost of healthcare for working people go through the roof but you can't do anything for them on other issues of affordability from fertilizer to gas and everything else—yeah, you know what? The American public doesn't like that much." - Sen. Josh Hawley (R-MO) speaking to reporters about Republicans' midterm losses. Hawley is one of the most significant members of the GOP's right wing, though he has frequently clashed with Trump over matters of policy.

On the Radar

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

15 December: Senator-elect Sherrod Brown (D-OH) is sworn in, reducing Republicans' Senate majority to 52-48.

3 January: New Congress is sworn in

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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